

What is the most efficient way of getting a number of similar initiatives to improve their implementation and performance?

In a number of situations, purchasers/funders are funding initiatives that consist of somewhat similar services delivered in a number of different branches, places or settings. How best can such localized services be helped to optimize their service design and implementation and improve their performance? The traditional approach is for the purchaser/funder to have one-on-one interactions with each of the local services or initiatives.

An alternative is to use the Group Action Planning for Implementing Multiple Similar Initiatives Tool (F3). In this approach, in addition to essential, one-to-one interaction with the local services, one person is selected from each initiative to take part in ongoing Group Action Planning networking. They are not necessarily high on the local service or initiative's hierarchy. They just need to be motivated and have the time to focus on service design, improvement and innovation.

At an initial workshop, participants are told that the purchaser/funder will be working with the Group Action Planning group over a number of years as the branch or local services or initiatives are rolled out and implemented. It's good to have these meetings independently chaired (e.g. by implementation evaluator (s)). An evidence-based, generic DoView strategy/outcomes diagram can be developed for, or at, this initial workshop. The different local implementations can then adapt this generic DoView diagram to their particular settings.

The group then works together face-to-face and/or virtually over the course of a set of ongoing Group Action Planning workshops, sometimes over several years. This approach has the following advantages: it is less expensive than one-to-one interaction; local sites can work collectively on how they will implement the initiative and measure outcomes; each of the sites provides peer review and input to the other sites (there is less of a feeling that someone at 'the center' is telling sites what to do (particularly important in community programs)); evidence can be introduced into the workshops about what works; the group can work on identifying and removing shared external barriers limiting the effectiveness of the branch or local iterations of the service; and the write-up of the workshops can form process documentation for evaluating the implementation of the service.